CORE FALSE BELIEF #12 · OTHER PEOPLE

“People cannot be trusted.”

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Where it often comes from

This belief usually comes from betrayal: a parent who broke promises, abuse by someone who should have protected us, a spouse’s unfaithfulness, gossip, or being cheated. After being hurt, it makes sense to protect ourselves. But when the lesson becomes “no one can ever be trusted,” we can end up isolated, suspicious, and unable to receive the support we need.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is realistic about people. It warns that it is better to take refuge in the Lord than to trust in man, and Jesus told His followers to be shrewd as snakes and innocent as doves. Wisdom means trusting carefully, not blindly. But the Bible also calls us into community, forgiveness, and love. Our full trust belongs to God, who never fails. Because He is trustworthy, we can risk measured trust with people, give it gradually, and watch whether it is honored.

> *“When I am afraid, I put my trust in You. In God, whose word I praise— in God I trust. I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?”* (Psalm 56:3–4).

Also see

> “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight” (Proverbs 3:5–6).

> “But blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose confidence is in Him” (Jeremiah 17:7).

> “It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man” (Psalm 118:8).

> “Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves” (Matthew 10:16).

Common self-statements

- Everyone has a hidden agenda.
- If I trust, I’ll get hurt.
- People always let you down.
- I can only count on myself.
- Kindness is just a setup.
- It’s safer to keep everyone at arm’s length.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralization: Deciding everyone is untrustworthy because some people betrayed me.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either trust completely or not at all.
- Mind reading: Assuming people have bad motives without evidence.
- Fortune telling: Predicting betrayal before it happens.

Challenging questions

- Who betrayed my trust, and what did I learn from it?
- Is there anyone who has proven trustworthy over time?

- Can I trust someone a little without trusting them with everything?
- What signs show that a person is trustworthy?
- What does God say about where my full trust belongs?
- What small risk of trust could I take with a safe person?

Truth summary

> Some people have betrayed me, and I am wise to be careful. But not everyone is untrustworthy. My full trust belongs to God, who never fails. Because I am secure in Him, I can offer trust to people gradually and wisely, and watch whether it is honored.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Friendship
- Wisdom
- Forgiveness
- Refuge/Safety

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Truth

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
Following God involves trust and surrender without needing control of every outcome.

Whom Shall I Fear — Chris Tomlin
God's presence provides courage without requiring a life free of difficulty.

Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn directs attention to Christ when fear or earthly concerns dominate.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "People cannot be trusted"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"People cannot be trusted." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who betrayed my trust, and what did I learn?
- ☐ Who has proven trustworthy?
- ☐ Can I trust someone a little?
- ☐ What signs show someone is trustworthy?
- ☐ Where does my full trust belong?
- ☐ What small risk of trust can I take?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ When I am afraid, I can trust God.
- ☐ Wisdom means trusting carefully, not never.
- ☐ Some people have proven trustworthy.
- ☐ Trust can be built step by step.
- ☐ My security rests in God.
- ☐ Forgiving does not require trusting blindly.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 56:3–4**
  "When I am afraid, I put my trust in You. In God, whose word I praise— in God I trust. I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"
- ☐ **Proverbs 3:5–6**
  "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."
- ☐ **Matthew 10:16**
  "Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Trust I tested: Each day, write one small way you trusted someone and whether that trust was honored.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 56:3–4 becomes: "David can write: "When I am afraid, I put my trust in God. With Him, I can risk trusting wisely.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Make a trust ladder. List small, medium, and large things you could trust someone with. Start with one small item this week.
- [ ] Name who has been faithful. Write the names of people who have kept their word to you, even in small things.
- [ ] Watch, then decide. With a new person, look for consistency between words and actions over time before deciding.
- [ ] Get help for deep wounds. If betrayal or abuse still feels raw, talk with a counselor or pastor about healing and safe boundaries.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “People cannot be trusted”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Trust that was honored
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~People cannot be trusted.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have been hurt by people I trusted. Thank You that You are completely trustworthy. Heal my wounds, give me wisdom to see who is safe, and courage to trust carefully again. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.